May, when the BJP lost Karnataka, the only southern state under its rule, to the Congress. Out of the 29 seats the BJP won in the 2019 general election from the total of 130 in the six southern states, 25 came from Karnataka alone, the other four from Telangana. With the Congress now having won both states, the BJP may have a tough time improving its tally in the South even if Modi's personal popularity helps the party hold on to what it won in 2019. In Karnataka, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has fixed a target of at least 20 seats for the Congress, while in Telangana, A. Revanth Reddy's leadership may brighten the GOP's chances of eating into the limited seats the BJP does have in these states. The BJP is not giving up without trying, though. In Karnataka, it has appointed B.Y. Vijayendra, son of former chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa, as state president in a bid to get the Lingayats back on its side and entered into an alliance with H.D. Deve Gowda's Janata Dal (Secular) to earn Vokkaliga support. But it is still early days yet.

BJP'S EASTERN CONCERN

The BJP does not have a firm grip over the four eastern Opposition-ruled states—Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha and Jharkhand—either. Of their 117 parliamentary seats, the BJP won 54 in 2019. But with Mamata and the TMC reasserting themselves and if INDIA gets its act together, the BJP may find it difficult to retain the 18 of Bengal's 42 seats it won in 2019. A similar fate could befall its 2019 tally of 17 out of 40 seats in Bihar if the JD(U)-RJD combine of Nitish and Tejashwi endures. Maharashtra is another uncertain prospect. The state gave the BJP 23 of its 48 seats in 2019 and 18 to its then ally, the undivided Shiv Sena. While the BJP is confident of retaining its share, it is not so sure if its coalition partners—the Shinde faction of the Sena and the breakaway Nationalist Congress Party headed by Ajit Pawar—can hold their own. Things don't look good in Haryana either. The BJP made a clean sweep of its 10 seats in 2019, but with growing anti-incumbency, an encore seems difficult. The stakes may be lower in Punjab, as the BJP has only two seats to defend, but with the Aam Aadmi Party running the show, the Congress resurgent and the Akali Dal trying to claw its way back, capturing more seats out of the state's 13 will be a challenge.

The only states the BJP can be confident of sweeping are the three it has won recently, and Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat and Assam. Together, these constitute 185 seats, of which the BJP won 159 on its own in 2019 and its ally another two seats. Its wins in the north may perhaps have a spillover effect in Maharashtra and Bihar, and maybe in some pockets of the South. In all, the BJP begins with the advantage of having around 160 of the 543 seats in its pocket. It needs 112 more seats from the remaining 383 to cross the simple majority mark of 272. Going by past records, the BJP is likely to draw a blank in some 100 seats in the South, which will leave it with 283 seats in other battleground states to find its majority. On the face of it, the task seems eminently doable, but a landslide win will require plenty of heavy lifting.

More than arithmetic, it's Modi's chemistry with the electorate that can deliver on the BJP's expectations. The August 2023 INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation poll showed that despite his 10th year as prime minister, Modi's popularity continues to hover above 50 per cent, as does the rating of his government's performance. He can still be the single most important factor in a third win for the BJP, as there is no alternative—in personality or narrative—to dislodge him from his lofty perch. Experts, though, warn the ruling party to guard against complacency, or arrogance, which could force missteps in the run-up to the general election.

But even as Modi is conscious of his aura of invincibility, he is not taking 2024 for granted. In fact, he wants to win it with the highest possible mandate. The successful conduct of the G20 summit in September had already given his image a boost in the eyes of the public, which saw him as enhancing the country's prestige on the global stage. Shortly afterward, he pulled another rabbit out of the hat when Parliament passed the Women's Reservation Bill. The inauguration of

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



SAFFRON WAVE Jubilant BJP supporters at the party office in Delhi, Dec. 4